

JOINT APPEAL

Imran Khan and Jemima

PRESIDENT, Tehrik-e-Insaaf

Former Pakistan cricket captain Imran Khan could never manage to translate his popular appeal to electoral strength for his Tehrik-e-Insaaf party. His support to General Musharraf during the controversial referendum of 2002, which he later admitted was a wrong move, and his often controversial confluence of opinion with religious parties such as the Jamaat-e-Islami has also cost him support from the intelligentsia. But his implacable opposition to Musharraf in recent times has won him admirers and for a change, he hopes to channelise a nascent student movement. He went underground after November 3 but was arrested on his first appearance at a protest at Punjab University on November 14 and charged under the Anti-terrorism Act. With him having accepted Bhutto's olive branch to unite against General Musharraf, it remains to be seen how former wife Jemima, who called Bhutto "a kleptocrat in a Hermes scarf" in a British newspaper, pursues her protest for democracy in London.

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THE RIGHT STUFF

Asma Jahangir

CHAIRPERSON, Human Rights Commission

The most well-known of the civil society campaigners of the country, the chairperson of the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan, Asma Jahangir, was put under detention soon after the declaration of "Emergency" for organising a meeting to discuss the political situation in the country. A tireless crusader for justice and a lawyer herself, Jahangir has been extremely critical of General Musharraf's policies, especially in the insurgency-infested Balochistan province and with regards the American-backed "war against terror". She was among those who moved the Supreme Court for action to recover those who had illegally "disappeared" and has openly called for international condemnation of Musharraf's abrogation of the Constitution. Musharraf has mocked her as "quite an unbalanced character" but she represents an increasingly vocal and activist civil society, which while still small in number has opinion-making ability and international connections.

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